

Beyond the Weapons: Allegation or Facts



Representative of the International Press Corps in conversation with the delegate of Russia on the fine line between cooperation and accountability

Q1: It is prohibited under the sanctions policy of the UN for North Korea to export any armaments; however, it has been found that many countries in the UN have engaged in a large number of military transactions with the North Korean and Russian governments. How can Russia justify its stance against illegal weapons trafficking?

A: We have always maintained our foreign policy based on international law and the UN Charter. The claims regarding North Korea are largely coming from Western countries and intelligence reports, which Russia does not consider reliable.

Russia believes sanctions should not be used simply for political pressure. Any allegations regarding weapons transfers must be properly investigated and supported by evidence rather than assumptions.

Q2: Delegate you have frequently emphasised the importance of evidence when allegations of weapons transfers are made. What specific evidentiary standard does Russia believe should be met before the UN publicly attributes an illicit weapons transfer to a state?

A: Russia believes in having a clear and independently verified evidence before a country is accused. A photograph of a weapon or satellite image alone cannot prove which country transferred it.

The UN should first identify the weapon, its serial number, manufacturer and original export documents where possible. It should then look at the route through which the weapon reached

the conflict area. There should also be evidence showing who actually authorised the transfer. A weapon manufactured in one country can later be sold, stolen, captured or transferred by another country.

We are not saying that states should never be held responsible. But the evidence must be strong enough to establish responsibility before public attribution is made.

Q3: Following Russia's veto of the renewal of the UN Panel of Experts monitoring DPRK sanctions, does the Russian Federation support the creation of an alternative independent mechanism to verify alleged weapons transfers, including transfers involving Russia itself?

A: We do not oppose verification. Our concern was mainly with the way the Panel of Experts was operating and the lack of objectivity in some of its reports.

A new mechanism can be considered, but it must be genuinely independent and should work under the United Nations, not under groups created by a few Western countries.

Russia has also criticised the use of satellite images and media reports as if they are complete proof of an arms transfer. These can be useful, but they are not always enough to establish responsibility.

If such a system is fair and does not target one country, Russia would have no reason to oppose it.

Q4: Delegate you have criticised Western weapons transfers to conflict zones as destabilising, while Western states have raised concerns about Russian military cooperation with other sanctioned states. How does Russia propose for distinguishing legitimate military assistance from state-enabled proliferation?

A: The main difference is whether the assistance is being given to a recognised government or to an armed group operating outside government control.

Russia believes sovereign governments have the right to request military assistance for their defence, but this is different from secretly supplying weapons to rebel or terrorist groups.

The problem is that Western countries have often supported armed groups in different conflicts and described it as support for freedom or self-defence. We believes the same standard should apply to everyone.

If a state is giving weapons to another government through a legal agreement, it should not automatically be called proliferation. But if weapons are secretly transferred to armed groups without the consent of the government concerned, that is a different matter.

Q5: If credible evidence establishes that a state has repeatedly facilitated the transfer of weapons to a non-State armed group, what consequences does Russia believe are proportionate and how should the international community respond when that state is itself a permanent member of the Security Council?

A: If there is clear evidence that a state is deliberately supplying weapons to an illegal armed group, there should be consequences. The rules cannot depend on whether that country is powerful or not.

Possible measures could include stopping the particular weapons supply, investigating the companies and intermediaries involved, and imposing appropriate sanctions where they are legally justified.

As for permanent members of the Security Council, such as US, they should not receive special immunity simply because they are P5 members.

Russia's position is that the same principle must apply to every country. If Western states facilitate weapons transfers to armed groups, they should face the same scrutiny as Russia or any other state.